

DECODED EXPLAINED

11th August, 2026

Trivedi Meets PM Rahman in Dhaka, R&AW Chief There for Security Talks

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Hope process for Hasina extradition expedited by India: Bangladesh PMO

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, August 10

FIVE DAYS after ousted Bangladesh Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina's remarks in India angered Dhaka, Bangladesh Prime Minister Tarique Rahman raised the issue of her extradition with Indian envoy Dinesh Trivedi Monday and underlined the need to "create a conducive environment to further advance the bilateral relations between the two countries".

Trivedi's meeting with Rahman coincided with the visit to Bangladesh by a top-level Indian intelligence and security delegation, led by R&AW chief Parag Jain. *The Indian Express* has learnt.

The delegation, which reached Sunday, is meeting officials from the DGFI (Directorate General of Forces Intelligence), the premier intelligence agency of Bangladesh.

Trivedi's meeting with Rahman was his first after assum-

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Shadow amid bid to reset ties

Hasina's presence in India has cast a shadow on ties between Delhi and Dhaka. Her recent statements and plans to return have sparked outrage in Bangladesh. The first meeting between Indian envoy Trivedi and Bangladesh PM Tarique Rahman is aimed at bringing ties back on track. Rahman's visit to India is at stake.

ing charge as the Indian High Commissioner. The Bangladesh PMO, in a statement, said, "Bangladesh expressed the hope that India would expedite the process of extraditing Sheikh Hasina."

Hasina is facing a death sentence in Bangladesh and her party, the Awami League, has been banned. Forced to flee the country on August 5, 2024 in the wake of violent protests, she has been living in India for the last two years.

Five days ago, addressing

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Early Phase

West Pakistan discriminated the East Pakistan on various grounds

International Mother Language Day : The United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO) declared 21st February as International Mother Language Day in 1999, celebrating it globally since 2000 to promote linguistic and cultural diversity and multilingualism.

The theme for International Mother Language Day 2026 is "Youth Voices on Multilingual Education."

The day commemorates the sacrifices made during the Bangla Language Movement in Dhaka (then East Pakistan) on 21st February 1952, where students were killed while advocating for the recognition of their mother language, Bangla.

Awami League got brute majority in 1970 election

Pakistan launched Operation Searchlight

Liberation Phase (1971–1975)

Marked by deep political trust and strategic convergence following Bangladesh's independence

India played a decisive role in the 1971 Liberation War:

Military intervention leading to Pakistan's surrender

Shelter to ~10 million refugees from East Pakistan

1972 Treaty of Friendship, Cooperation and Peace drawing a framework for long-term cooperation

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Reversal Phase (1975–1990)

Triggered by the assassination of Sheikh Mujibur Rahman (1975)

Emergence of military regimes (Ziaur Rahman, H.M. Ershad)

Democratic Flux Phase (1990–2009)

Restoration of democracy but marked by political oscillation:

Awami League (pro-India) vs BNP (more sceptical of India)

Partnership Consolidation Phase (2009–2024)

Period of unprecedented stability and deepening cooperation under Sheikh Hasina

Strong convergence on security, connectivity, and economic integration

Strategic Uncertainty Phase (2024–Present)

Emerging phase marked by political transition and strategic recalibration

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About Research and Analysis Wing (RAW)

It is India's external intelligence agency.

It plays a crucial role in counter-terrorism, counter-proliferation, cybersecurity, and monitoring threats from outside the country.

It is headquartered in New Delhi.

Until 1968, the Intelligence Bureau (IB), which is responsible for India's internal intelligence, also handled external intelligence.

However, after the 1962 China-India war and the Indo-Pakistani war in 1965, India established a separate and distinct external intelligence organization—the R&AW.

It directly comes under the prime ministerial office of India.

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Consider the following statements :

1. 21st February is declared to be the International Mother Language Day by UNICEF.
2. The demand that Bangla has to be one of the national languages was raised in the Constituent Assembly of Pakistan.

Which of the above statement is/are correct?

This question was previously asked in
UPSC Civil Services Exam
(Prelims) General Studies Offici...

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1. 1 only

2. 2 only

3. Both 1 and 2

4. Neither 1 nor 2

The MSME Opportunity Lies in Clustering Them



NILANJAN BANIK
& PRADEEP RACHERLA

The MSME opportunity lies in clustering them

THE RECENT protests at Jantar Mantar reflected a deeper problem than the paper leak controversy: Youth unemployment. A large share of unemployed Indians are young and educated, while underemployment remains widespread. With AI-driven disruption threatening existing jobs, India needs strong job creation engines, and the MSME sector is one of the best candidates. The Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises Development (Amendment) Bill, 2026, can help by addressing delayed payments, easing dispute resolution, and reducing some compliance burdens. But more needs to be done. India's 63 million MSMEs employ more than 320 million people, contribute about 31 per cent of GDP, 35 per cent of manufacturing output, and 49 per cent of exports. Yet the sector remains largely informal, fragmented, and concentrated in low-value activities. Smaller firms face major obstacles, especially limited access to affordable credit and the burden of GST, labour, environmental, and tax compliance.

The US and China did not create industrial strength by supporting isolated firms; they built clusters — dense ecosystems where suppliers, labour, research institutions, and capital are located close together and reinforce one another. The US experience shows how universities can anchor clusters. In North Ca-

Clusters create knowledge spillovers. Technical know-how spreads quickly through worker mobility, informal interaction, and shared service providers. Clusters also attract and retain talent

rolina's Research Triangle, institutions such as Duke, UNC-Chapel Hill, and NC State helped build biotechnology and pharmaceutical ecosystems by connecting research with industry. China's Guangdong shows how industrial zones with land, tax incentives, and infrastructure can create thick supplier networks, allowing firms to design, fabricate, and prototype quickly. China's "Little Giant" programme also supports technically strong small firms in narrow niches through financing, tax support, and R&D assistance.

Clusters create knowledge spillovers. Technical know-how spreads quickly through worker mobility, informal interaction, and shared service providers. Clusters also attract and retain talent. An isolated MSME struggles to hire specialised workers, but a cluster creates a real labour market and makes the location more attractive. Third, clusters lower fixed costs by sharing infrastructure such as testing labs, effluent-treatment plants, cold storage and logistics hubs.

India already has cluster-based initiatives such as the MSME Cluster Development Programme and PM MITRA textile parks. However, many of these function more like infrastructure grants than true ecosystem builders. The following policies may help. First, India should move from generic industrial estates to specialised clusters. Resources should be concentrated

in sector-specific hubs such as auto components in Pune and electronics in Sriperumbudur. Second, India should create its own version of the Little Giant programme. Policy should identify "hidden champions" already performing well in specialised fields like precision castings or defence components. These firms could receive dedicated credit lines, faster patent processing, R&D support, and priority procurement.

Third, financing should be addressed at the cluster level. The MSME credit gap is large, but banks still assess firms individually. Cluster-based lending, which evaluates shared collateral, buyer-supplier ties, and collective performance, can reduce information asymmetry and lower risk. The Tiruppur textile cluster offers a useful model that could be expanded through SIDBI and cluster-focused NBFCs. Fourth, universities must be brought to the centre of the MSME ecosystem. In India, top universities often remain disconnected from nearby industry. In contrast, Chinese and US cluster models rely on universities as suppliers of talent, lab infrastructure, and innovation. In short, India's MSME strategy should shift from isolated support to ecosystem-building. Strong clusters, better finance, and closer university-industry links can help MSMEs become engines of jobs, productivity, and exports.

The authors are professors and co-founders, Economic Policy Centre, Mahindra University

The MSME Opportunity Lies in Clustering Them

India's 63 Million MSMEs — An Outsized Economic Footprint

320 mn+

people employed

31%

share of GDP

35%

share of manufacturing
output

49%

share of India's
exports

The MSME Opportunity Lies in Clustering Them

● Why Clusters Matter

- China's 'Little Giant' programme supports technically strong small firms in narrow niches through financing, tax support, and R&D assistance; clusters create knowledge spillovers, attract and retain talent, and lower fixed costs by sharing infrastructure like testing labs and logistics hubs
- India already has cluster-based initiatives like the MSME Cluster Development Programme and PM MITRA textile parks, but many function more like infrastructure grants than true ecosystem builders
- Recommendations include moving from generic industrial estates to specialised clusters, creating India's own 'Little Giant' programme for hidden champions, addressing financing at the cluster level through models like the Tiruppur textile cluster, and bringing universities to the centre of the MSME ecosystem

Do Not Write the Obituary of International Law Yet

Do not write the obituary of international law yet

Is international law really dying? The question has become increasingly difficult to ignore. The ongoing conflicts in Ukraine and Gaza, instability in West Asia, violence against civilians, and the inability of international institutions to respond effectively, have led many to conclude that international law is no longer relevant.

International law was premised on the idea that relations between states should be governed not merely by power, but by rules and legal principles built on consensus. When wars still take place, the effectiveness of the system is naturally exposed to scrutiny. However, it would be too early to write an obituary for international law.

'It will prevail'

In July 2026, while addressing the International Law Commission recently, United Nations Secretary-General António Guterres remarked that "international law is under pressure – but it will prevail". The second half of the statement deserves as much attention as the first. International law undoubtedly faces serious challenges, but it continues to shape the conduct of states and remains the language through which international disputes are contested.

Paradoxically, wars actually demonstrate why international law still matters. Had it really become irrelevant, the states concerned would not bother to justify their actions by referring to international law. They invoke the UN Charter, sovereignty, territorial integrity, self-defence and international humanitarian law. Even states accused of violating international law rarely argue that the law itself is meaningless. Rather, they claim that their actions are consistent with it. A legal system under which states continue to justify their conduct cannot simply be described as dead.

International law scholars Abram Chayes and Antonia Handler Chayes argued that states often comply with international law not because they are threatened with sanctions, but because they



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International law remains relevant in a troubled world

are influenced by the dynamics created within the treaty regimes to which they belong. It is a pertinent observation even today. The significance of international law cannot be determined only by instances of violation; it also lies in providing a framework through which state conduct is assessed, disputes are addressed and cooperation is sustained. The difficulty is that compliance goes unnoticed whereas violations dominate headlines.

The quiet power of international law

The quiet accomplishments of international law are visible every day. Aircraft fly across international boundaries because states comply with international aviation regulations. Ships sail across seas because of international maritime law. Diplomacy functions because governments observe established legal norms. International trade, communications and travel continue because states honour thousands of international obligations. Even as armed conflicts continue to dominate headlines, states still negotiate multilateral legal agreements. Recent endeavours such as the High Seas Treaty, international efforts towards pandemic preparedness, and the United Nations Convention against Cybercrime demonstrate that states continue to rely on international law. International law also affects individuals. The moment a person crosses an international border, international law begins to matter. The recognition of passports, consular assistance, international air travel and the protection of refugees all depend upon international legal rules. We often notice international law only when it fails, but millions of people rely on it every day.

The continued relevance of international law is perhaps most evident in the way states seek peace, which is built through negotiations, commitments and legal arrangements. Whether these are described as peace agreements, ceasefire arrangements, diplomatic understandings or negotiated settlements, even

adversarial states recognise the need for legal commitments that establish expectations and obligations for the future. India provides a good example in this respect. India's experience with the Indus Waters Treaty demonstrates that even during periods of political discord, legal frameworks continue to provide a basis for engagement between states. That is precisely why international law remains indispensable for India and the wider Global South. The problems of climate change, pandemics, cyber-attacks, and economic instability cannot be addressed unilaterally by any state. They require cooperation, which in turn depends on agreed rules of conduct. A rules-based international order provides an opportunity to developing states to protect and advance their interests through negotiations rather than power alone.

There are imperfections

The reality is that international law has never been perfect. It has always coexisted with political realities and has frequently been condemned for reflecting unequal power structures. Recent conflicts have reinforced these criticisms, revealing the structural limitations within the UN Security Council and the broader international legal order. However, these are not reasons enough for the abandonment of the system altogether. No legal system can guarantee perfect compliance. Its significance lies in establishing the standards against which conduct can be judged. History suggests that crises have rarely marked the end of international law. More often, they have prompted its adaptation and renewal.

International law is under pressure, but it is far from dead. The greater danger is the growing belief that its violations prove its irrelevance, a conclusion that serves only those who prefer a world in which might makes right. As long as states continue to invoke, interpret and rely on international law, its obituary is being written far too soon.

Do Not Write the Obituary of International Law Yet

● The Question Under Scrutiny

○ Is international law really dying? Ongoing conflicts in Ukraine and Gaza, instability in West Asia, and the inability of international institutions to respond effectively have led many to conclude international law is no longer relevant

○ International law was premised on the idea that relations between states should be governed not merely by power, but by rules and legal principles built on consensus; when wars still take place, the system's effectiveness is exposed to scrutiny, but it would be too early to write its obituary

● 'It Will Prevail'

○ In July 2026, addressing the International Law Commission, UN Secretary-General António Guterres remarked that 'international law is under pressure, but it will prevail'

○ Paradoxically, wars actually demonstrate why international law still matters; had it really become irrelevant, states would not bother to justify their actions by referring to it, they invoke the UN Charter, sovereignty, self-defence and humanitarian law, and even accused states rarely argue the law itself is meaningless

Do Not Write the Obituary of International Law Yet

● The Quiet Power of International Law

- The quiet accomplishments of international law are visible every day, aircraft fly across borders because of aviation regulations, ships sail because of maritime law, diplomacy functions because governments observe legal norms
- Even as armed conflicts dominate headlines, states still negotiate multilateral legal agreements; recent endeavours such as the High Seas Treaty, pandemic preparedness efforts, and the UN Convention against Cybercrime demonstrate continued reliance on international law

● India's Experience and Imperfections

- India's experience with the Indus Waters Treaty demonstrates that even during periods of political discord, legal frameworks continue to provide a basis for engagement, making international law indispensable for India and the wider Global South
- International law has never been perfect and has frequently been condemned for reflecting unequal power structures, but history suggests crises have rarely marked its end, more often they have prompted its adaptation and renewal

'Series of Technical Failures' Preceded 300-ft Plunge by Air India Flight; Probe Continues

'Series of technical failures' preceded 300-ft plunge by Air India flight; probe continues

Jagriti Chandra
NEW DELHI

The “momentary loss in altitude” of the Air India flight from Phuket in Thailand to Delhi on August 4, which injured 17 people aboard, was preceded by a cascade of failures involving the aircraft’s hydraulic and flight-control systems, said multiple sources familiar with the matter, contradicting the airline’s initial attribution of the incident to turbulence.

Flight AI 2379, undertaken in an Airbus A320neo aircraft, experienced technical failures at cruising altitude nearly two-and-a-half hours after take-off. The sequence involved low-pressure indications



An injured passenger of Air India flight AI 2379 being assisted by a medical personnel after arriving in New Delhi on August 4. ANI

and failures affecting hydraulic systems, according to a source who has reviewed the automated post-flight maintenance report. This was followed by an autopilot disconnect and simultaneous fault indications affecting both the left and right elevators, which are the control sur-

faces that move the aircraft’s nose up or down.

The A320neo has three independent hydraulic systems that power critical functions. The maintenance report records failures and warning indications in the systems, occurring either individually or in combinations,

but affecting all three of them, according to the source. The report recorded nine such messages within one minute. Several pilots described the near-simultaneous failure of three of the hydraulic systems as extremely rare.

The Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau (AAIB) is probing the incident and has classified it as ‘serious’. An Airbus team is expected to arrive on Tuesday to assist with the AAIB probe, while France’s aviation safety investigation authority, the Bureau of Enquiry and Analysis for Civil Aviation Safety, will also join the investigation.

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'Series of Technical Failures' Preceded 300-ft Plunge by Air India Flight; Probe Continues

Institutional Frameworks for Aviation Security in India

Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA)

Regulatory body in the field of Civil Aviation, primarily dealing with safety issues.

Responsibility: Regulation of air transport services to/from/within India and for the enforcement of civil air regulations, air safety, and airworthiness standards.

Also coordinates all regulatory functions with the International Civil Aviation Organisation (ICAO).

Airports Economic Regulatory Authority of India (AERA)

Established in 2009 under the Airports Economic Regulatory Authority of India Act, 2008.

Objective: To regulate tariffs for aeronautical services, determine other airport charges for services rendered at major airports and monitor the performance standards of such airports.

Bureau of Civil Aviation Security (BCAS)

Initially set up as a cell in the DGCA in 1978 and later reorganised into an independent department under the Ministry of Civil Aviation in 1987.

Major Responsibility: It lays down Aviation Security Standards per Annex 17 to the Chicago Convention of ICAO.

'Series of Technical Failures' Preceded 300-ft Plunge by Air India Flight; Probe Continues

Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau

It was established in 2012 as an attached office under the Union Ministry of Civil Aviation.

It facilitates investigation and administrative work of the Court or Assessors appointed by the Central Government under the Aircraft (Investigation of Accidents and Incidents) Rules, 2017.

Mandated for immediate and unrestricted access to all relevant evidence from any agency/organisation without seeking prior consent from judicial bodies or other Government authorities.

All Accidents and Serious Incidents involving aircraft with an All-up Weight (AUW) of more than 2250 kg or Turbojet aircraft are investigated by AAIB.

Investigations into occurrences involving an aircraft of maximum mass of 2250 Kg or less, which are classified as Serious Incidents, are carried out by DGCA.

Agasthyamala : Next Class

Thank You